

The Killer Whale Debate: Captivity vs. Conservation

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WRIT 105S: Sustainable Communications

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October 18, 2025



Left (Times of San Diego Aug. 5, 2025)

Photo taken at SeaWorld San Diego



Right (Pacific Offshore Expeditions Sept. 27, 2025)

Photo taken south of Santa Rosa Island, Santa Barbara Channel

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Many people can say that they have a love for the ocean; however, not as many people can say that they have a passion for the preservation of our oceans and the conservation work that it takes to protect species, high biodiversity habitats, and other critical aspects of our oceans such as coral reefs, and marine sanctuaries. The ocean is one of the most important areas of our earth, by acting as the largest natural carbon sink; as well as being home to millions of diverse species. The ocean is widely discussed and intertwined with many cultures all over the world. People from all over the world are very passionate about the conservation of the oceans, and especially the species it holds, this creates conflicts when discussing the best ways to encourage more people to work in marine conservation due to the vast variety of perspectives on what marine conservation means and how sustainable the use of marine theme parks is to inspire others to work in marine conservation efforts. Yet, when it comes to communicating marine conservation, the conversation around killer whale captivity and other marine mammals shows how sustainability discourse can become skewed by profit focused corporations and the overuse of emotional rhetoric rather than science and research. The debate of whether or not marine mammals belong in captivity exposes a major flaw and disadvantage in sustainability communication: both advocacy and activist groups along with corporate institutions rely on the use of emotional rhetoric and profit-driven narratives rather than supported science-based dialogue used by academia and government agencies such as NOAA. This distortion of communication harms public understanding of conservation and weakens progress toward sustainable marine protection and conservation efforts.

SeaWorld is one, if not the main driver in this debate between captivity and conservation. SeaWorld is difficult to assess and analyze as a corporation for many reasons; the primary one being, SeaWorld has an entertainment and profit-driven theme park system which expands both

nationally and internationally. The second aspect to the SeaWorld Corporation is the Hubbs SeaWorld Research Institute, a non-profit research driven organization that focuses on creating sustainable solutions through science. This organization states that while a separate entity from SeaWorld, “HSWRI continues to collaborate with SeaWorld on scientific research on marine life and ocean health and both organizations serve as “first responders” in marine animal rescue.”

(*Research overview*. (n.d.) This creates a paradox of main intentions between the two adjacent corporations. Each of these companies have different mission statements and goals even though they are respectively the same organization. The mission statement of SeaWorld theme parks and amusement parks is to inspire guests to care and protect wild animals and the natural world through experiences, rehabilitation, animal rescue, and conservation. (*SeaWorld San Diego theme park*. (n.d.) This does align with the actions of SeaWorld as they have continuously adapted their “Orca Encounter” shows that provide guests a look into the life of orcas. SeaWorld states that guests will witness orcas behave naturally accompanied with a film shown on an infinity screen that shows an in depth look of killer whales (*SeaWorld San Diego theme park*. (n.d.) These “natural behaviors” are done on the trainer’s command. Many of the orca were bred in captivity and have never felt the natural ocean environment, and therefore have never learned social and behavioral cues, hunting strategies, and lessons typically passed on by the mother and other family members.

Orcas (*orcinus orca*) are very intelligent cetaceans and are able to do these behaviors as they were trained; however, these orcas are not displaying these behaviors in the same way they would in the ocean. This creates a problem when trying to spread awareness for ocean conservation because while these orca encounters do inspire people to care, it can be argued that a better approach to inspiring more people to care is to get them out into the ocean environment.

Get onto whale watching tours and expeditions that allow people to see orcas in their natural environment performing natural behaviors that are not learned or called on command. The price of a day admission ticket to SeaWorld is approximately \$123. This is not far off from the typical whale watching tour cost of approximately \$150. This adds to the argument that it could be more sustainable and more ethical to increase the number of whale watching tours and accessibility.

However, with every argument there is a downfall, not all whale watching companies act ethically and many do not follow the guidelines in place that regulate the distance from whales, speed while in whale migration patterns and other precautions. Another downfall to this argument is the wide range that different ecotypes of killer whales span, this makes it difficult to encounter killer whales on every trip, in fact it is quite rare depending on the location. While the ethical and moral debates of marine mammal captivity are very complex and controversial, the conservation actions and efforts of SeaWorld are not as commonly discussed as the captivity debate. This includes the work done by Hubbs SeaWorld Research Institute that works constantly on mitigating the impacts of climate changes onto marine species. This is the main reason why the discourse in the sustainability communication of both marine conservation and marine mammal captivity is so complex, it is not a good or bad type of issue and it requires the involvement of more than just one industry, company or ideal. One of the greatest examples of a challenge with sustainable ocean conservation and education is this problem of discourse within sustainable marine conservation awareness and inspirational efforts.

On the other hand, a widely known advocacy and animal rights activist organization: Peta, has a one sided approach to marine mammal captivity that focuses solely on the ethical and moral implications of marine mammal captivity rather than including the conservation and educational aspects. Peta frames captivity as a form of cruelty and exploitation. In their argument the use of

emotional visuals of suffering animals and “lonely” whales prioritizes moral outrage over scientific nuance or importance (*Marine parks* 2010, June 23. PETA.) This form of conveying information is often widely accepted, many people see this and will conform with that idea and believe that captivity is cruel and inhumane. The problem with this form of communication is it only shows one side of the argument. It does not show the years of work done by aquariums and zoological institutions to help promote and foster ocean conservation work and research.

The third primary contributor to this debate is the world of academics and marine scientists and biologists. There are many academic sources and publications that dive deeper into the ethical implications of marine mammal captivity and the pros and cons of aquariums and other marine zoological institutions. Many universities and other academic institutions also provide studies into the educational benefits and downsides of SeaWorld along with the benefits of having aquariums and zoological parks working on their conservation efforts such as Monterey Bay Aquarium. For example one source highlighted the fact that while SeaWorld does rescue thousands of animals a year it is not as black and white as the company makes it seem. “Twenty five years (1997-2002) of live-stranded odontocete data from northern California was evaluated and results show that of the 70 rescued for rehabilitation only five were released back into the wild (5%), three were placed into captivity because they were deemed non releasable (4%) and the other sixty two animals died within hours to months of being rescued.” (Patama, K. L. 2017). A Odontocete refers to a toothed whale so this data includes much more than just orcas. Odontocete stranding data is collected and managed by both regional and international agencies that restrict access for the public due to the information disclosed in these reports. The primary source of this data for the US is NOAA (*National oceanic and atmospheric administration*. n.d.) This is just one example from a single source that helps support the argument that this is not a

black and white, good vs. bad debate. This is a social, ethical, moral, and scientific issue that requires an in-depth and well analyzed way of communication that is sustainable: a way of communication that inspires future generations without implementing the ethical and moral implications of keeping marine mammals in captivity. A true sustainable approach will be a “just” sustainability: The need to ensure a better quality of life for all, now and into the future, in a just and equitable manner, whilst living within the limits of supporting ecosystems” (Agyeman, J. (2020).

Both PETA and SeaWorld claim to be on the moral high ground of sustainability, but neither provides clear and in depth transparent science communication. PETA urges the public to not buy tickets to marine parks using the rhetoric method of pathos to influence, by the use of vivid imagery and comparisons, without providing any in depth behavioral data partly due to the lack of accessibility for the public. SeaWorld theme parks selectively uses research along with the term education to justify the primary focus of entertainment and profit. This discourse is highly problematic and it creates a simplified approach to a very complex social, moral, economical, and environmental issue. It urges this debate to be viewed in a good vs. bad perspective. It persuades the public’s emotions and opinions rather than building educational programs and communication about how important our oceans are and what they do for our planet and species that call them home. The marketing and advertising used by these corporations overshadows the scientific research and literature that is published on this issue. Real sustainable communication requires honest dialogue and transparency that uses emotional rhetoric in support of the argument rather than evidence itself. Ultimately, the discourse on this issue provides a large complex problem needed to be solved with a well analyzed and in depth approach that relies on data and science rather than emotional rhetoric as an educational communication tool.

References

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